

HOSTAGE IN THE SKIES : A FLIGHT ATTENDANT'S COURAGE

'Thank you for flying with us! ' The last passenger alighted the plane. All the drained crew and I headed to the other end of the flight, grabbing each of our luggage. After a quick check around the flight, we disembarked after a 14-hour journey from Boston to Dubai.

As I made my way to the metro, I felt a frisson of apprehension, then an odd sense of foreboding that something terrible was going to happen. A minute later, the train arrived. As the doors opened, the vacant seats relieved my tired legs. My watch showed 3 hours until my birthday. At 23, my birthday has become a day of tranquillity. A day to fully appreciate my internal growth. A perfect gift that only I can afford to give myself. Next year at this time, I will be a better person. I shall relax for the next two days before the long journey.

Time passed by swiftly. The day for my next destination arrived.

Clad in my uniform, feeling a sense of pride with each footstep into the airport. I welcomed my journey with a strong core showing off a solid prudence of confidence that boosts within me. My flight from Dubai to New York with a layover at Islamabad added 13 hours of flying time. Welcoming 150 people on board while smiling was exhausting. Settling down passengers is a tiring job. The aircraft slowly took off while sentimentally watching the view of Dubai and saying goodbye. Within a blink of an eye, we reached Islamabad. Half of the passengers exited the flight. A new set of passengers entered with a fáilte greeting on board. One hour later, we departed from Islamabad to New York, our final destination.

After 40 mins, ten men wearing skull-face masks got up and silently moved places. Ten seconds later, BANG! A 5mm bullet shot from the gun hit the hard curved surface of the overhead cabin. People began to panic, the babies screamed, and the elderly hyperventilated at the sounds of the weapon. Two terrorists yelled, "PUT your HANDS UP!". Frightened passengers could only obey. One of them pulled my hair harshly and whispered in my ear, "Collect all the passports of these people and give them to me." The crew and I quickly begged all the passengers to hand in their passports. As I was collecting, a sudden plan came to me to inform the cockpit about the current situation. " Excuse me, can I go to the washroom quickly," I asked a terrorist, " Go!". I rushed to the toilet. I found a secret keyboard. I typed in a code: mayday, hijack on the plane.

Little did I know that one of the hijackers was already in the cockpit. One out of 2 pilots was dead. They blackmailed another pilot with a sharp knife right to his neck to contact the Islamabad officials to send another pilot. "Send me a new pilot ", with a pause, " otherwise the passengers die. " In the next few minutes, we were on our detour to Islamabad.

On the deck, I heard another gun go off. The victim was a passenger. Soon, the explosions occurred again and again. For the six people, death was the final destination.

I had to save all these passengers. Poor passengers looked from every eye with mantras of prayer running line by line on their lips. My brain had worked up a solution. From an announcer, I spoke in English, a language terrorists had no awareness of, " Stay calm, keep your eyes down. If you are seated in the window row, please listen. If you are ready to join me in bringing terrorists down, lift your chin." Slowly, many chins lifted. I carefully observed the terrorists pacing the corridors with their weapons. When they were away from me, I rose quickly. Twenty outside seated men pounced on the terrorists. Within minutes, the hijackers were on the ground. After confiscating their weapons, I grabbed some zip ties and tied their hands behind them.

The commotion alerted the third terrorist in the cockpit. He ran to the deck with a rifle in his hand. While I punched his stomach, Haru kicked the back of his knees. The gun slipped in the aisle as it fell. Soon the ten men were disarmed and restrained. One of the passengers got out the duct tape from his backpack. Tightly, we taped their lips.

I went into the cockpit and updated the pilot about the situation. Within an hour, we will be landing at Islamabad. Haru contacted the airfield in Islamabad, updating them on the ten terrorists and their clandestine weapons. Despite the comfort level within the aircraft, the passengers were highly cautious and vigilant. Some with tears continued prayers while a few cuddled with relief.

One hour later, we touched down in Islamabad and waited. Passengers rejoice to hear the sirens. We waited until the police arrested the ten men and the ambulance took the dead driver. Slowly, passengers began to relax in their seats. Diener removed the dead bodies from the plane. The police and government would take responsibility for the deceased. After refuelling, two new pilots boarded. We continued to fly to New York.

"That was a thrilling start to 23," I told myself.